

touch with young people and use their tools, their devices, their social networks to obtain information, to use feedback.

Q. On another note, how did the disintegration of Soviet Union impact you?

A. It had an impact in a sense that we always need to look at every step very carefully and understand its consequences. That's number one. Number two, it is very important not only for the former Soviet Union but also for Russia. What was the conclusion I came to? That the Soviet Union at a certain point of time was in such a state that its leadership and possibly even ordinary citizens always believed it was so big, so great that nothing, ever, under any circumstances, would happen to it. And this idea of grandeur is the point when a country starts to make one mistake after another, thinking yes, we made a mistake here and it was a small failure there, but we are so big, it will all pass, we'll survive. And the number of mistakes snowball and it gets harder to manage that. I see the same happening with some other countries today. Therefore, I am keeping an eye. We need to think how to create a system that will not simply protect itself, but develop. If such a system is in place, it would be self-sufficient, autonomous and effective.

Q. Are you looking at the reintegration of Soviet Union?

A. No, of course not, that's simply not on the table. There is also a question of rationale. It does not make sense in current circumstances because it would critically change the national and religious composition of the Russian Federation.

Q. In your span as leader of Russia, which of our prime ministers do you think has really made a difference in strengthening India-Russia ties?

A. You have already asked me about other world leaders. It is not very polite, but we have very trustworthy and friendly relations with Prime Minister Modi. He is a very reliable person. India got lucky. He lives India. That's number one. Number two, indeed, he is very sincere when he goes about strengthening Indian-Russian ties across a whole range of areas, especially crucial issues of economy, defence, humanitarian cooperation and development of hi-tech.

Q. There was a moment between President Xi and you when you spoke about longevity, the strides in medicine through biohacking, which went viral. Do you think immortality is achievable?

A. Everything has an end, only God is eternal. I am one hundred per cent sure we can extend longevity of life. Seventy-seven years ago, the average lifespan of a person in India was 31 years; now, it's about 70. These are all the results of the healthcare effort and if you use AI in healthcare and use it to produce medical drugs, for example, using genetic engineering and so on, it would have a tremendous effect. Nevertheless, everything comes to an end. ■

"To achieve freedom, we must use lawful means only. Any actions involving criminal methods or those harming people cannot be supported. We fully support India's fight against terrorism"

"Every country has problems, Afghanistan is no exception. To influence events there, one has to be in contact with their current leadership. And the Taliban clearly controls the situation there"